

Steven Johnston

TECHNICAL LEAD & SOLUTIONS ARCHITECT

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SC CLEARED

CCNP ENTERPRISE

CCNP COLLABORATION

PROFILE

Technical leader designing and delivering secure, enterprise-scale infrastructure for public sector and critical national infrastructure clients. I operate at lead architect level: owning end-to-end architecture, setting technical standards and governance across concurrent programmes, and seeing complex multi-vendor deployments through from first principles to production.

My expertise spans networking, security, cloud and AI-driven automation. I have led zero trust and Secure by Design implementations for critical national infrastructure, architected cloud platforms that bring agentic AI into infrastructure operations, and championed DevOps adoption (CI/CD, infrastructure as code and automated testing) across delivery teams. I currently manage and mentor a team of seven consultants, balancing immediate delivery needs against long-term scalability, security and maintainability, and translating complex technical decisions for stakeholders from engineers to executive boards.

KEY SKILLS

Architecture & Strategy: Enterprise and solution architecture, technical strategy and roadmaps, design governance and assurance, high-level and low-level design, standards definition, design authority

Cloud & Hybrid: Public cloud networking and security (Azure), hybrid connectivity, transit hub architectures, multi-region resilient design

AI & Automation: Agentic AI for IT operations, large language model integration, Python, infrastructure as code

Leadership: Team leadership and mentoring, programme delivery, supplier and stakeholder management, executive communication

Security & Secure by Design: Zero trust architecture, secure access service edge (SASE), identity-based network access control, next-generation firewalls, secure remote access

Networking: Enterprise WAN and software-defined WAN, campus and datacentre networks, routing and traffic engineering

DevOps & Delivery: CI/CD pipelines, automated testing, agile delivery across concurrent programmes

EXPERIENCE

Technical Lead

2024 – Present

Sword Group (formerly Ping Network Solutions)

- Designed and delivered a resilient, multi-region zero trust network and security architecture in the public cloud for a **critical national infrastructure client**, spanning identity-based access control, next-generation firewalls and software-defined WAN
- Architected a secure cloud-based AI platform to automate network operations workflows, integrating large language model tooling with enterprise infrastructure to reduce manual effort and accelerate incident response
- Define solution architecture and set technical standards across concurrent projects, ensuring consistency, quality and alignment with client outcomes through design reviews and architectural governance
- Manage and mentor a team of 7 consultants, owning resource planning, technical direction and professional development across concurrent delivery programmes
- Led a multi-datacentre and offshore transformation programme, modernising wide area networking, datacentre switching and edge security
- Delivered campus-wide security and network refresh programmes across multiple Scottish public sector clients, including colleges, universities and government bodies, coordinating third-party suppliers throughout
- Championed DevOps practices (CI/CD pipelines, infrastructure as code and automated testing) to accelerate and de-risk delivery

Consultant Engineer

2019 – 2024

Ping Network Solutions

- Designed and implemented end-to-end solutions spanning networking, security and collaboration technologies for enterprise and public sector clients
- Led a multi-site migration from a legacy VPN estate to a modern software-defined WAN architecture
- Architected resilient hybrid cloud connectivity built around an active/active security transit hub in the public cloud
- Managed the migration of 2,000 users from on-premises telephony to a cloud collaboration platform for a major Scottish university
- Designed and built a bespoke hosted management platform across dual datacentres for an energy sector client

Principal Engineer

2015 – 2019

Virgin Media Business

- Provided technical leadership and consultation for large public sector accounts
- Delivered a comprehensive network and datacentre redesign for a national justice sector organisation
- Led a datacentre compute and infrastructure refresh for a secure public sector estate
- Designed and implemented a secure video conferencing system for a custodial environment, connecting inmates, solicitors, police and court personnel
- Delivered multiple large infrastructure projects including network refreshes, firewall migrations and voice integrations

Senior Network Engineer

2007 – 2015

Jabil

- Led a European-wide network and telephony refresh across 112 manufacturing sites
- Delivered two \$3M datacentre builds in London and Budapest
- Served as technical lead for the acquisition integration of a competitor facility in the Netherlands

Network Engineer

2003 – 2007

Jabil

- Managed converged data and voice network installations across the European region
- Designed routing and traffic engineering solutions for international networks
- Delivered VPN, telephony and wireless solutions across multiple European sites

CERTIFICATIONS & CLEARANCE

SC Cleared UK Government Security Clearance (current)	CCNP Enterprise Routing & Switching · valid through 2027
CCNP Collaboration Unified Communications · valid through 2027	Cisco Specialist Certifications Multiple · valid through 2027

PORTFOLIO

AI tools & agentic workflows: tools.clydeford.net, a working collection of AI tools and agents exploring agentic workflows and LLM integration with infrastructure operations